

TRANSIT

Analysis: What It Would Take To Put America First in Transit Again

No, it won't be easy. Yes, it can be done.



By Kea Wilson



7:00 AM EST on January 14, 2026



Photo: Jac Alexandru

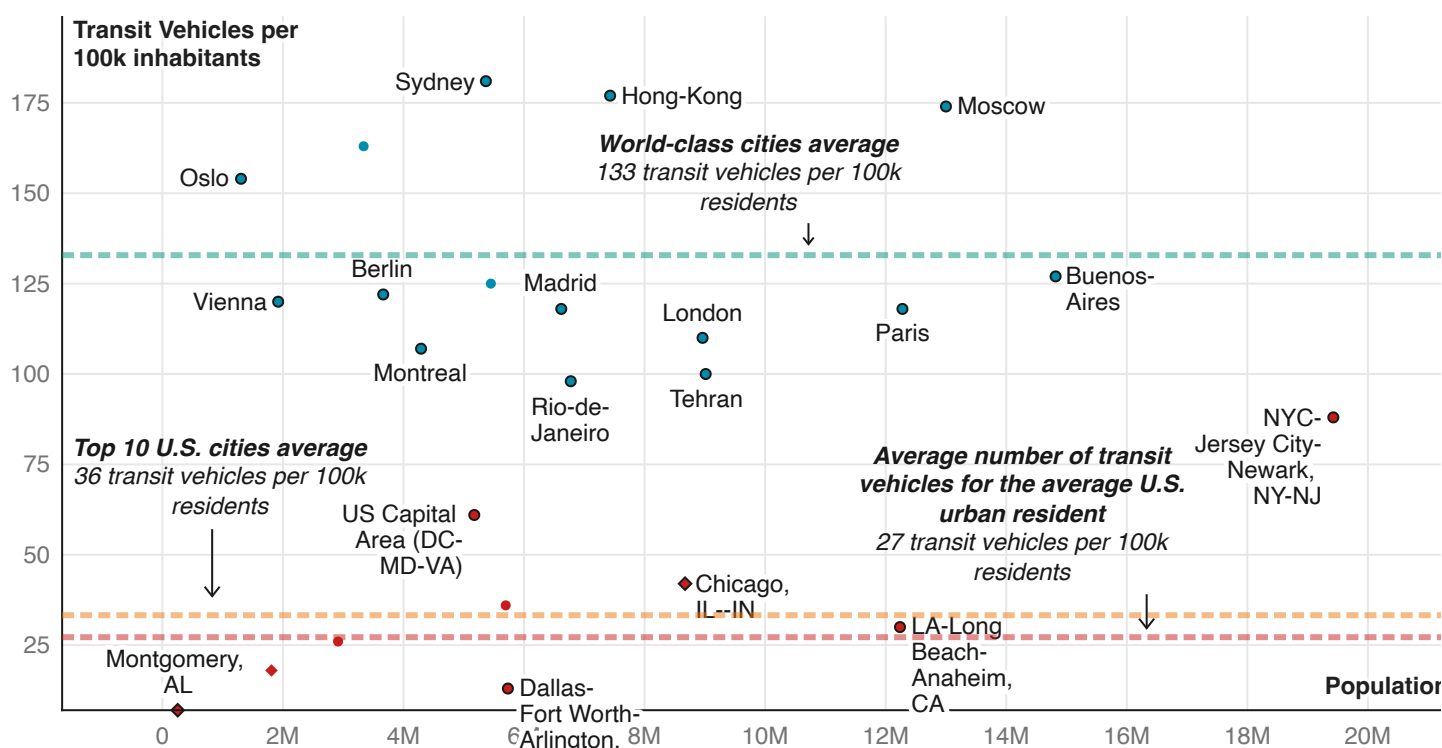
It's not too late for Americans to get the world-class transit networks they deserve — and it wouldn't take as long *or* cost as much as we spent building

highway system, a new analysis finds.

A new analysis from Transportation for America found that a \$4.6-trillion “moonshot” over the next 20 years would be enough to bring the transit networks in most American cities up to par with world-class communities like Berlin, Paris, Oslo and Buenos Aires, which all have more than 115 transit vehicles on the street and underground per 100,000 residents — not to mention excellent service and dedicated rights-of-way to match.

The average U.S. city, by contrast, has just 27 buses and trains per 100,000 people, which is an international embarrassment by comparison.

Transit service in U.S. cities falls drastically short of global standards

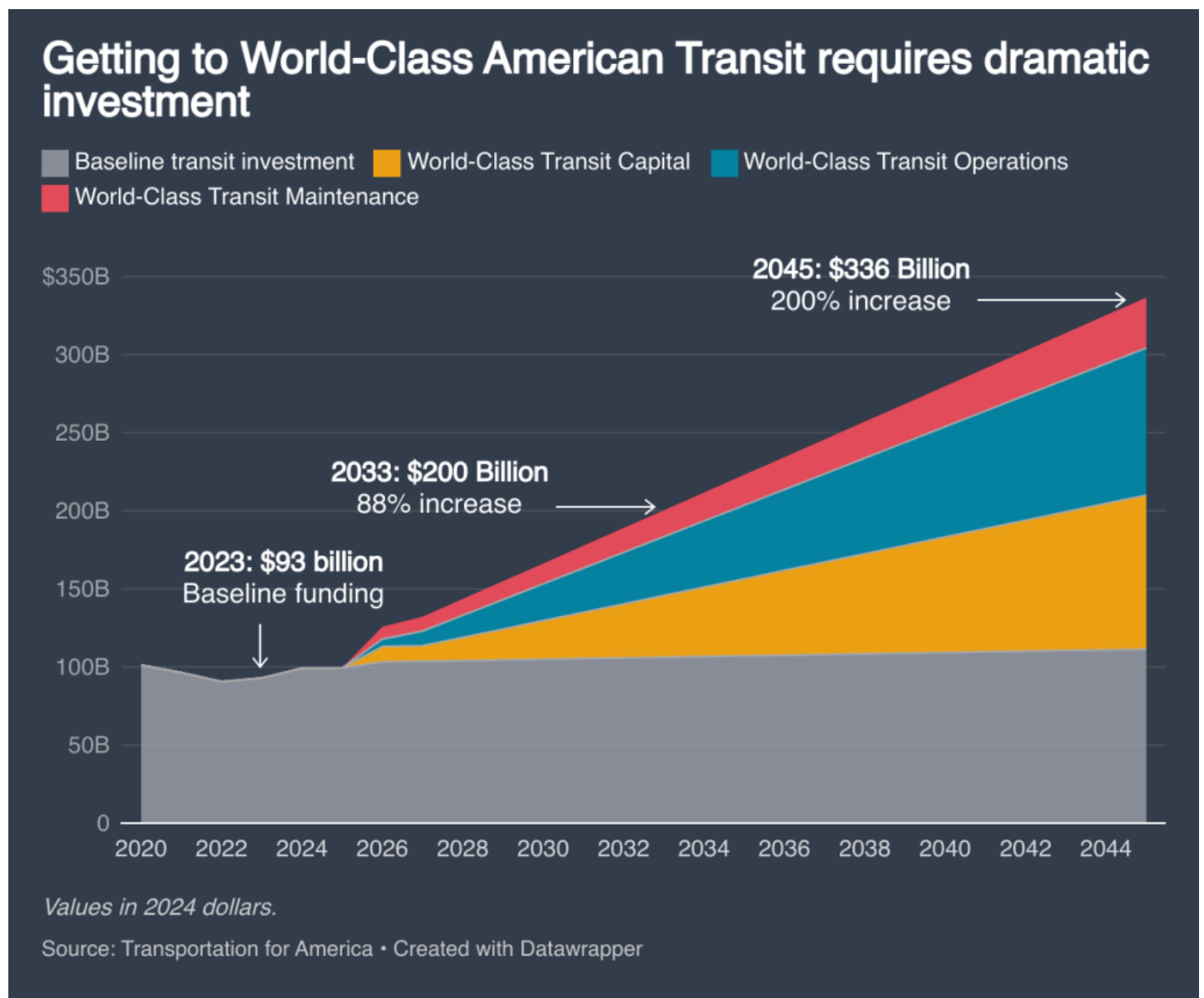


Analysis of NTD vehicles operating in maximum service in urbanized area and fleet data from UITP's CityTransitData

Considering that it would mean tripling the national transit budget, spending \$4.7 trillion in 20 years might sound like a big ask — except that America is already on track to spend an additional \$6.3 trillion on highways over the next two decades. Since the Federal Highway Act of 1956, the country's *already* spent \$9.6 trillion more on moving drivers than moving people on shared modes, creating a massive network of autocentric roads that many experts agree is already so badly overbuilt that many states cannot afford to maintain it, with little to show for it besides stratospheric road deaths, stubborn congestion, and dangerous levels of air pollution.

As the balance of the Highway Trust Fund continues to plummet — and with Congress due to pass a new federal transportation law that could replace that broken system in September — the study authors say the moment is ripe to put all the “America First” rhetoric to use and reclaim our place at the top of the global hierarchy of transit-building nations. Or at least, to recognize what an astonishing global outlier we are when it comes to giving people basic transportation options, and finally do something about it.

“This is something that we’ve fallen behind on in global leadership, and it’s a policy choice that hasn’t delivered for us,” said Corrigan Salerno, the lead author of the report. “All these other countries are able to get significantly better per-dollar investment benefits for their infrastructure by investing in compact growth and transit.”



To understand just how far American transit lags behind its peers and how to close the gap, Salerno used the number of transit vehicles per capita as a rough proxy for how well its residents are served by their local networks. And while he acknowledges that's not a perfect approach, in part because cities with walkable, bikeable neighborhoods may not *need* as big a stable of buses and trains, he argues that's probably the most comparable data we've got about transit around the world — and the top-ranking cities *do* mostly track with what many people would subjectively consider some of the best transit systems, too.

“If you’ve ever traveled to places that have [great transit], you know you what that looks like,” he added. “You’re able to get where you want to go, to do your daily errands. ... If a place has a high number [of transit vehicles per capita], we tend to feel it in our daily mobility experiences, which give us a high level of freedom. And if it’s a low number, we *feel* locked into the car.”

Car dependency has also locked countless U.S. households into paying for transportation they can't really afford. The study authors estimated that if we keep pouring asphalt this rate, American households will spend more than \$77 trillion on car ownership between 2026 and 2045 — an unthinkable sum that few affordability advocates have really bothered to challenge.

If a moonshot \$4.6-trillion transit investment could reduce the rate of car ownership by just one-quarter of a percent each year — a rate which the study authors say is “conservative” — the analysis estimates it would save Americans over \$5.4 trillion just from the costs of car ownership that could be avoided — meaning that taxpayers' investment would more than pay for itself.

“That would translate to real savings for folks and actual freedom to choose how they want to spend their money, rather than being forced to spend it on transportation,” Salerno added.

Moreover, all of those savings would be on top of the billions of dollars *governments* could save by shifting money to modes that are less expensive to maintain, rack up fewer public health costs by killing fewer people, and stimulate economic activity, more than building roads only for drivers. And that means money to devote to other priorities like healthcare, education, and more.

Urbanized Area (UZA)	Transit fleet: World-Class American Transit	Transit fleet size % increase	Bus fleet: 2023	Bus fleet: World-Class American Transit	Urban rail fleet: 2023	Urban rail fleet: World-Class American Transit	Commuter rail fleet: 2023	Commuter rail fleet: World-Class American Transit
Williamsport, PA	30 vehicles	10%	27 buses	30 buses	0 urban trains	0 train cars	0 commuter trains	0 commuter trains
San Marcos, TX	53 vehicles	11%	48 buses	53 buses	0 urban trains	0 train cars	0 commuter trains	0 commuter trains
Champaign, IL	110 vehicles	19%	93 buses	110 buses	0 urban trains	0 train cars	0 commuter trains	0 commuter trains
Morgantown, WV	29 vehicles	19%	24 buses	29 buses	0 urban trains	0 train cars	0 commuter trains	0 commuter trains
Ames, IA	65 vehicles	20%	54 buses	65 buses	0 urban trains	0 train cars	0 commuter trains	0 commuter trains
New York-Jersey City-Newark, NY-NJ	20,722 vehicles	22%	8,073 buses	9,858 buses	5,773 urban trains	7,050 train cars	3,123 commuter trains	3,814 commuter trains
Blacksburg-Christiansburg, VA	46 vehicles	22%	38 buses	46 buses	0 urban trains	0 train cars	0 commuter trains	0 commuter trains
Lewiston, ME	44 vehicles	26%	35 buses	44 buses	0 urban trains	0 train cars	0 commuter trains	0 commuter trains
Ithaca, NY	38 vehicles	27%	30 buses	38 buses	0 urban trains	0 train cars	0 commuter trains	0 commuter trains
Burlington, VT	81 vehicles	27%	64 buses	81 buses	0 urban trains	0 train cars	0 commuter trains	0 commuter trains

Note: Transit fleet includes only vehicles operating in maximum service. Vanpool and demand response, and other transit vehicles excluded from totals. Urban rail includes both light rail and heavy rail vehicles.

Source: [National Transit Database \(2023\)](#) • [Get the data](#) • Created with [Datawrapper](#)

Salerno acknowledges that some might argue America has gone too far down the autocentricity rabbit hole to pull itself out now, even if Congress and local communities somehow all agreed to collaborate on a moonshot moment. He points out, though, that some urbanized areas are far closer to World Class status than they might think — and not necessarily the ones that you’d guess.

In an analysis of all U.S. urbanized areas over 50,000 people, Salerno found that places like Williamsport, Penn., San Marcos, Texas, Ames, Iowa, and Morgantown, W. Va. all would need less than a 20-percent increase to their local transit fleet to make them competitive with the rest of the transit-riding world (though, to be fair, Morgantown gets a big boost from its controversial personal rapid transit system.)

The transit-leading metro area surrounding New York City also doesn’t have far to go, either, requiring less than 100 miles of new bus rapid transit lanes to bring them up to the global par — and Salerno points out that’s largely because relatively car-dependent Newark and Jersey City are lumped into their numbers, and the fact that all cities on the list were adjusted for relative density.

Those are rough estimates, but the report authors say it's important for US residents to see just how close their communities might be to a transit revolution — and how even big numbers, like adding 11,621 buses to the streets of metro Los Angeles, are actually fairly attainable relative to the heaven and earth we routinely move to accommodate more car traffic, even decades after we proved that doing it doesn't cut congestion. And he particularly encourages advocates to find their own metros to help make that case to transportation leaders.

“When we have these kind of big numbers, It helps put into perspective what actually is the norm for other cities outside of the United States,” Salerno adds. “[Having a certain number of buses] means reducing 30 minute headways down to five minutes on certain routes; it means ensuring that entire new areas are covered by that transit service. ... It's [transit as an] actual, viable feature in the community.”

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New York-Jersey City-Newark, NY-NJ	20,791 vehicles	22%	8,073 buses	9,858 buses	5,773 urban trains	7,050	3,123 commuter trains	3,814 commuter trains
Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim, CA	13,097 vehicles	257%	3,252 buses	11,621 buses	218 urban trains	779	195 commuter trains	697 commuter trains
Chicago, IL-IN	7,425 vehicles	104%	1,832 buses	3,746 buses	838 urban trains	1,714	960 commuter trains	1,963 commuter trains
Miami-Fort Lauderdale, FL	6,505 vehicles	422%	1,096 buses	5,726 buses	84 urban trains	439	43 commuter trains	225 commuter trains
Houston, TX	5,012 vehicles	435%	884 buses	4,733 buses	52 urban trains	278	0 commuter trains	0 commuter trains
Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington, TX	4,908 vehicles	567%	612 buses	4,081 buses	81 urban trains	540	43 commuter trains	287 commuter trains
Philadelphia, PA-NJ-DE-MD	4,267 vehicles	108%	1,339 buses	2,790 buses	383 urban trains	798	326 commuter trains	679 commuter trains
Washington-Arlington, DC-VA-MD	4,431 vehicles	41%	2,144 buses	3,015 buses	908 urban trains	1,277	99 commuter trains	139 commuter trains
Atlanta, GA	2,729 vehicles	262%	592 buses	2,143 buses	162 urban trains	586	0 commuter trains	0 commuter trains
Boston, MA-NH	3,283 vehicles	69%	1,089 buses	1,838 buses	440 urban trains	743	406 commuter trains	685 commuter trains

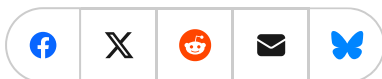
Graphic: Transportation for America

Of course, it will take a lot more than just buying buses and building train lines to truly transform America into a transit titan. The analysis also explores how increasing service and overhauling transit maintenance might look in a

moonshot scenario, while acknowledging that rethinking land use to put all those new bus and train stops within easy reach was too much for this particular report to tackle.

Salerno also acknowledges that such a bonanza for buses and trains would require an incredible imagination just to *fund*, which the report didn't have space to delve into — though considering that 85 percent of all ballot measures for transit have passed in recent years across communities of all sizes, the public appetite for that conversation is clearly strong. And while raising trillions would need to involve the federal government, he points out that if we did it for highways 70 years ago, we can do it again for the shared modes that Americans are actively demanding.

“We’re hoping to start a discussion about what types of policies would be needed for this level of urban transformation,” he added. “[And it needs to be at] the same scale and ambition as what we had for the Federal Aid Highway Program, where we instituted a massive, never-before-seen tax on drivers. We accepted that bargain because it was building out something we had decided was worthwhile. We would need for the same thing for transit.”



Kea Wilson

Kea Wilson is Senior Editor for Streetsblog USA. She has more than a dozen years experience as a writer telling emotional, urgent and actionable stories that motivate average Americans to get involved in making their cities better places. She is also a novelist, cyclist, and affordable housing advocate. She lives in St. Louis, MO. For tips, submissions, and general questions, reach out to her at kea@streetsblog.org, or on Bluesky [@keawilson.bsky.social](https://bsky.app/profile/keawilson.bsky.social).



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